



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Headwaters Christian Academy
School Website: <https://southriverbaptist.com/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Headwaters Christian Academy NC 28625 is a Christian school operating within the South River Baptist Church network in Statesville, NC. Public-facing materials from the school's crawl indicate a strong explicitly Christian orientation (Bible-focused content, references to God and Jesus, and church-linked infrastructure), but there is little to no explicit evidence of foundational classical elements such as Great Books, the Trivium/Quadrivium, or the formal pedagogy and community structures that characterize a classical education. On the classical rubric used here, the school displays clear Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, but lacks robust articulation of classical curriculum, pedagogy, and institutional practices that would place it in the Classical or even Somewhat Classical categories for most of the six rubrics. The aggregate reading is: NOT CLASSICAL.

Key contextual notes from the sources: - The Headwaters Academy content appears on the South River Baptist Church site, including explicit references to Headwaters Academy Website and the physical/address details showing integration with a local church community in Statesville, NC 28625. This evidences a church-centered educational program rather than a self-described classical school with an internal Great Books ecosystem. See evidence showing "Headwaters Academy Website" and the Statesville address on the church site.

- The site also contains explicit Christian content (e.g., references to "God," "Jesus," and biblical verses), which confirms a theological framing of education, though not a fully developed classical curriculum narrative. For example, biblical reflections and questions about the names of God appear in the crawl materials. - Context from classical-education scholarship in the knowledge base highlights the core elements of Classical Christian education (theology integrated into curriculum, liturgical learning, Great Books, the Trivium/Quadrivium, scholé, etc.). These sources provide the rubric against which the Headwaters materials are measured. See the Six Essential Elements rubric and the accompanying keyword lexicon.

- For reference on how to identify and weigh positive vs. negative indicators (the keyword approach), the knowledge base explicitly lists the positive/negative indicators for each category (Religious Foundations, etc.). This framework is used to score each category in the Element-by-Element snapshots that follow.

Overall, the Headwaters materials show a strong religious foundation but do not demonstrably meet the core corpus of Classical elements across the six categories. The aggregate classification is NOT CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - School materials are embedded in a Christian context, with explicit God-centered content visible in crawl items (e.g., discussions of names of God and biblical passages). This indicates a religious-metaphysical orientation that aligns with a theologically grounded education. - The Headwaters Academy materials appear within a church site, linking the school to a Christian worshiping community, which supports liturgical and communal dimensions of education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: theology, God, Jesus, biblical content, worship-oriented framing. These map onto the Positive Keyword set for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations (theology, sacred scripture, worship, etc.). The explicit biblical framing and the church context supply multiple positive signals. - Negative indicators: none evident in the public crawl for this category (no explicit movement away from transcendental moral realism or from sacred tradition in the visible public materials).

Why this rating - The public materials demonstrate a clear theological frame and liturgical/community orientation consistent with Grounded in Theology and Liturgical/Communal Practices. While the language of “truth, goodness, beauty” as a formal philosophical frame is not overtly stated, the explicit Christian metaphysical framework provides a robust religious grounding that, in classical terms, supports a favorable reading for this category. The combination of explicit biblical/theological content and church-based community practice aligns with the rubric’s expectations for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials show a Christian-educational context and a church-linked program, but there is no explicit articulation of formation for virtue and wisdom as the telos of education, nor a clear claim that truth, goodness, and beauty are real and knowable in a classical sense. The clearest public signals are religious rather than philosophical or humanistic aims.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords for Classical Education (e.g., formation, virtue, liberal education, telos, the true/good/beautiful) are not clearly present in the public Headwaters materials. - Negative signals: The content lacks explicit statements about human excellence, paideia, or the Great Conversation as the telos of education.

Why this rating - Without explicit articulation of classic aims (virtue formation as telos, formation over mere information, or the real knowledge of truth/goodness/beauty in a classical sense), the category fails to meet the core Element 2 criteria in the classical rubric. The religious framing alone is not sufficient to meet the classical purpose/goal benchmarks.

Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The crawl materials from the Headwaters site do not reveal a Great Books program, a Trivium/Quadrivium structure, or explicit emphasis on comprehensive classical literature or philosophy as the core curriculum. The visible content centers on church-related activities and operational details.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators: None specific to classical liberal arts or the Great Books. The presence of biblical content is relevant to Element 1 but not to the classical curriculum signals. - Negative indicators: Absence of terms like Great Books, grammar/logic/rhetoric, history as Western civ with canonical texts, Latin/Greek study, or explicit “Great Conversation.”

Why this rating - Because the public materials do not reveal the canonical classical curricular elements (grammar, logic, rhetoric; liberal arts; Great Books; history as Western civ rather than social studies; etc.), Element 3 is NOT CLASSICAL in the scoring framework.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials do not demonstrate the hallmark classical pedagogy (Scholé-based rest in contemplation, formal Socratic seminars in upper grades, chanting/memory in lower grades, or rhetoric instruction). The visible content is predominantly administrative/church-related rather than pedagogical in the classical sense.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators: None of the canonical pedagogy signals (Socratic seminars, memorization-based patterns, narration as core learning method, restfulness/scholé) are openly described in the public materials. - Negative indicators: The absence itself is a negative signal for this category.

Why this rating - Lacking explicit classical pedagogy signals means Element 4 cannot be rated Classical or somewhat Classical based on the known public materials. The school's public-facing content does not present the structured pedagogical framework typical of classical education.

Element 5: School Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - There is no public material in the crawl that describes faculty as “model teachers,” the “living curriculum,” or a “portrait of a teacher” as a core organizational idea. The material is church-organization oriented rather than classroom-faculty oriented.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators: None in the public material. - Negative indicators: Absence of a depicted faculty philosophy or “portrait of a teacher” language.

Why this rating - Without explicit statements about faculty as exemplars or the living curriculum, Element 5 fails to meet classical criteria.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public crawl does not reveal formal parent-education programs, parent formation offerings, open-campus policies, or explicit parent partnerships described as co-teachers. The church-affiliated materials emphasize events but do not articulate a classical-education community model.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators: None of the canonical parent-community indicators are evident (e.g., parent education, open campus, family liturgical rhythms as part of school life). - Negative indicators: Absence of “parents as co-teachers,” parent formation programs, or accessible on-campus visits as standard practice.

Why this rating - The absence of explicit classical-parent community practices places Element 6 in NOT CLASSICAL territory under the rubric.

What Would Move the Needle - If the school were to shift toward a CLASSICAL profile, substantive changes would include: - Explicit articulation of a classical purpose and telos (virtue formation, pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty) beyond church affiliation.

- Development and public articulation of a classical curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; history as Western Civilization; Latin/Greek as offered).
- Adoption and public description of classical pedagogy (Scholé/restful learning, memory work, narration, rhetoric training, Socratic seminars in upper grades).
- Clear faculty model statements (the living curriculum, teacher portraits, professional development in classical pedagogy).
- Strong parent/community scaffolding (parents as co-teachers, ongoing formation opportunities, open campus visits, formal partnerships and book clubs).
- Evidence of a Great Conversation with canonical texts and disciplined study in the curriculum.
- Public documentation of grade-level practices in K-12 that align with classical education (including upper-grade Socratic engagement and lower-grade chant/memory practices).

Note: No “needle-moving” changes are mandated by the current evaluation because the aggregate rating remains NOT CLASSICAL; the rubric section designed to guide improvements for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL schools is not triggered by this result. The suggestion above outlines what would move this school toward CLASSICAL status if the leadership intended to pursue a classical reform.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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